



German prisoners of war in France—in the last three months of the war 363,000 German soldiers were captured by the advancing Allies.

ALTHOUGH THE US ENTERED WORLD WAR I IN APRIL 1917,

at the start of 1918 its Expeditionary Force in Europe was still not ready for combat. Despite this, in anticipation of victory, US President Woodrow Wilson announced a **14-point program** for a just and durable peace. His proposals included freedom of the seas and free trade, general disarmament, self-determination for European peoples who did not have their own nation-states, and an international organization to guarantee new borders against aggressors. Germany would have to hand back the territory it had occupied during the war as well as Alsace-Lorraine, which was taken from France in 1871.

The Germans had quite different ideas, however. In March, they used their military dominance over the newly installed Bolshevik government (see 1917) to impose punitive peace terms on Russia through the **Treaty of Brest-**

Litovsk, which marked Russia's exit from World War I. With Poland, Ukraine, Belarus, Finland, and the Baltic States nominally independent as client states of Germany, the treaty deprived Russia of about a third of its prewar population. The German military authorities then set about ruthlessly exploiting resources in the eastern regions they now controlled.

The humiliating treaty did not bring peace to Russia, which was already slipping into civil war. Determined to concentrate all the power in Bolshevik hands, **Lenin forcibly dispersed a democratically elected Constituent Assembly** in January—the Bolsheviks had won only 25 percent of votes cast. His regime faced opposition from groups as diverse as rival socialist revolutionaries, czarist generals, Ukrainian anarchists, and Don Cossacks. Lenin survived an assassination attempt in August,

but throughout the year ever larger areas of Russia fell out of his followers' control.

Meanwhile, relieved of the need to fight a war on two fronts, Germany attempted to win a decisive victory in the west before American manpower could irreversibly tip the balance. On March 21, the **Spring Offensive** or "**Kaiserschlacht**" struck the British line on the Somme front.

An initial bombardment by 9,000 guns and mortars, with munitions including 2 million gas shells, prepared the way for an infantry attack spearheaded by German Stormtroopers, many armed with flamethrowers. More than 20,000 British troops surrendered on the first day of the offensive, and by March 25 the leading German units had advanced 40 miles (65 km). **The stalemate that had lasted on the Western front since 1914 was at an end.**

In early April, the Germans opened a fresh offensive at Lys in Flanders. In an emotional appeal to his troops, British commander General Douglas Haig (1861–1928) declared: "With our backs to the wall and believing in the justice of our cause, each one of us must fight on to the end." More practically, the French general **Ferdinand Foch (1851–1929) was appointed Supreme Commander** to coordinate the operations of the



MURDER OF THE RUSSIAN ROYAL FAMILY

After abdicating in 1917, Czar Nicholas II, his wife, four daughters, and only son were sent to Siberia, where they lived in reasonable comfort. But in April 1918 the family was moved to Ekaterinburg in the Urals and placed under close guard by local Bolsheviks. On the night of 16–17 July Bolshevik secret police had the entire family shot in a cellar, along with their doctor and servants. Their bodies were buried and not discovered until 1991.



Poster of a German aircraft
A German poster advertising an exhibition of items captured in the air war. Most World War I aircraft were made of canvas and wood.

Allied armies, including US troops. Although the Allies made further retreats and remained on the defensive until July, the Germans failed to achieve the decisive success they needed.

One victim of the fighting in April was Germany's most renowned air ace, Manfred von Richthofen (1892–1918). **The "Red Baron" was shot dead** by ground fire while engaged in a dogfight with Canadian pilot Roy Brown over the Allied lines. His death symbolized the exhaustion of Germany's war effort. Richthofen's fighter wing, known to the British as the

"Flying Circus," had an impressive reputation in combat and the Baron himself was credited with 80 "kills." But the German pilots were overwhelmed by the sheer number of allied aircraft—British and French factories built 55,000 aircraft in 1918 alone.

By June, over a **million American soldiers were in France**, under the command of General John Pershing (1860–1948). Their contribution was vital to stabilizing the Allied line in the face of German offensives. The fighting qualities of the US Marines particularly impressed

